Tourette’s Syndrome

In short

Tics are sounds or movements that someone with Tourette’s Syndrome can’t easily stop. Swearing is rare, and tics aren’t a choice. Don’t draw attention to them, and focus on what the person is saying.

Overview

Tourette's Syndrome (or Tourette Syndrome, in more medical settings) is a condition that's often misunderstood. Many people think that it's just about swearing, but that's actually quite rare (it's called coprolalia). It's mostly about tics, which are sounds or movements that someone can't easily stop.

It's important to remember that managing tics all day can be exhausting. Tics can increase when someone is stressed or tired, and trying to hide those tics can make it more difficult to focus. As well as this, other people can be judgemental about Tourette's, especially when they don't understand that it's not voluntary.

So how can you be a good ally to someone who has Tourette's Syndrome?

- Don't draw any attention to their tics
- Be patient if a tic happens during a conversation
- Focus on what the person is saying rather than the sounds
- Remember that tics aren't a choice or a habit, and the person can't choose how their tics show up

Useful links

- NHS: Tourette Syndrome
- Coprolalia

Abbreviations

The full form of each abbreviation used in this document.

NHS: National Health Service